

Open Source Zettelkasten Knowledge Management Systems

Feature comparison matrix of open source tools using the Zettelkasten approach. Research conducted 2026-02-23 via ar-crawl web crawling.

Overview

#	Tool	Stars	License	Language	Status
1	AppFlowy	68.2k	AGPL-3.0	Dart/Rust	Active
2	Joplin	53.6k	AGPL-3.0	TypeScript	Active
3	SiYuan	41.4k	AGPL-3.0	TypeScript/Go	Active
4	Logseq	41.2k	AGPL-3.0	Clojure	Active
5	TriliumNext	34.7k	AGPL-3.0	TypeScript	Active
6	Foam	16.9k	MIT	TypeScript	Active
7	Zettlr	12.5k	GPL-3.0	TypeScript	Active
8	TiddlyWiki	8.6k	BSD-3	JavaScript	Active
9	nb	8.0k	AGPL-3.0	Shell	Active
10	Dendron	7.4k	Apache-2.0	TypeScript	Unmaintained
11	Athens	6.3k	EPL-1.0	Clojure	Unmaintained
12	Standard Notes	6.3k	AGPL-3.0	TypeScript	Active
13	Org-roam	5.9k	GPL-3.0	Emacs Lisp	Active
14	QOwnNotes	5.6k	GPL-2.0	C++ (Qt)	Active
15	zk	2.5k	GPL-3.0	Go	Active
16	TidGi	2.0k	MPL-2.0	TypeScript	Active
17	Neuron	1.5k	AGPL-3.0	Haskell	Superseded
18	Rocketnotes	1.3k	Apache-2.0	TypeScript	Active
19	Emanote	925	AGPL-3.0	Haskell	Active
20	Memo	874	MIT	TypeScript	Low activity
21	Notabase	898	AGPL-3.0	TypeScript	Active
22	Zkn3	784	GPL-3.0	Java	Active
23	iwe	715	Apache-2.0	Rust	Active
24	vim-zettel	587	MIT	Vim Script	Active
25	Sublimeless_ZK	201	GPL-3.0	Python	Unmaintained

Feature Comparison Matrix

Legend: **Y** = Yes | **N** = No | **P** = Partial/Plugin | **--** = N/A

Core Zettelkasten Features

Tool	Bi-directional Links	Graph View	Tags	Block-level Links	Embeds/Transclusion
AppFlowy	N	N	Y	N	N
Joplin	P	P	Y	N	N
SiYuan	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Logseq	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
TriliumNext	Y	Y	Y	N	Y
Foam	Y	Y	Y	N	Y
Zettlr	Y	Y	Y	N	N
TiddlyWiki	P	P	Y	N	Y
nb	N	N	Y	N	N
Dendron	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Athens	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Standard Notes	N	N	Y	N	N
Org-roam	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
QOwnNotes	N	N	Y	N	N
zk	Y	N	Y	N	N
TidGi	Y	P	Y	N	Y
Neuron	Y	Y	Y	N	N
Rocketnotes	Y	Y	Y	N	N
Emanote	Y	Y	Y	N	Y
Memo	Y	Y	N	N	Y
Notabase	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Zkn3	Y	N	Y	N	N
iwe	Y	Y	Y	N	N
vim-zettel	Y	N	Y	N	N
Sublimeless_ZK	Y	N	Y	N	N

Editing & Content

Tool	Markdown	WYSIWYG	Templates	Daily Notes	Search
AppFlowy	Y	Y	Y	N	Y
Joplin	Y	Y	Y	N	Y
SiYuan	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Logseq	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
TriliumNext	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Foam	Y	N	Y	Y	Y
Zettlr	Y	P	N	N	Y
TiddlyWiki	P	N	Y	P	Y
nb	Y	N	Y	N	Y
Dendron	Y	N	Y	Y	Y
Athens	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Standard Notes	P	P	N	N	Y
Org-roam	N	N	Y	Y	Y
QOwnNotes	Y	N	Y	N	Y
zk	Y	N	Y	Y	Y
TidGi	P	N	Y	Y	Y
Neuron	Y	N	N	N	Y
Rocketnotes	Y	Y	N	N	Y
Emanote	Y	N	Y	N	Y
Memo	Y	N	N	N	Y
Notabase	Y	Y	N	N	Y
Zkn3	N	N	N	N	Y
iwe	Y	N	N	N	Y
vim-zettel	Y	N	Y	N	Y
Sublimeless_ZK	Y	N	N	N	Y

Platform & Extensibility

Tool	Plugins	Mobile	CLI	API	Web Clipper
AppFlowy	P	Y	N	Y	N
Joplin	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y

Tool	Plugins	Mobile	CLI	API	Web Clipper
SiYuan	Y	Y	N	Y	Y
Logseq	Y	Y	N	Y	N
TriliumNext	Y	N	N	Y	Y
Foam	Y	N	N	N	N
Zettlr	N	N	N	N	N
TiddlyWiki	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
nb	Y	N	Y	N	Y
Dendron	Y	N	Y	N	N
Athens	N	N	N	N	N
Standard Notes	Y	Y	N	N	N
Org-roam	Y	N	N	N	N
QOwnNotes	Y	N	N	N	Y
zk	Y	N	Y	Y	N
TidGi	Y	N	N	Y	Y
Neuron	N	N	Y	N	N
Rocketnotes	N	N	N	Y	N
Emanote	N	N	Y	N	N
Memo	Y	N	N	N	N
Notabase	N	Y	N	N	N
Zkn3	N	N	N	N	N
iwe	Y	N	Y	Y	N
vim-zettel	Y	N	N	N	N
Sublimeless_ZK	N	N	N	N	N

Data & Security

Tool	File-based	Self-hosted	Encryption	Version History	Offline	Collaboration
AppFlowy	N	Y	N	N	Y	Y
Joplin	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
SiYuan	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Logseq	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	N
TriliumNext	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	N

Tool	File-based	Self-hosted	Encryption	Version History	Offline	Collaboration
Foam	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	N
Zettlr	Y	--	N	N	Y	N
TiddlyWiki	Y	Y	P	N	Y	N
nb	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Dendron	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	N
Athens	N	Y	N	N	Y	Y
Standard Notes	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Org-roam	Y	Y	P	Y	Y	N
QOwnNotes	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
zk	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N
TidGi	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	N
Neuron	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N
Rocketnotes	N	Y	N	N	Y	N
Emanote	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N
Memo	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	N
Notabase	N	N	N	N	N	N
Zkn3	Y	--	N	N	Y	N
iwe	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N
vim-zettel	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N
Sublimeless_ZK	Y	Y	N	N	Y	N

Publishing & Export

Tool	Publish/Export	Export Formats
AppFlowy	Y	Multiple
Joplin	Y	PDF, HTML, Markdown, JEX
SiYuan	Y	PDF, HTML, Markdown
Logseq	Y	PDF, publishing
TriliumNext	Y	HTML, Markdown
Foam	Y	Static site (GitHub Pages)
Zettlr	Y	PDF, DOCX, HTML (via Pandoc)
TiddlyWiki	Y	Static HTML

Tool	Publish/Export	Export Formats
nb	Y	Many formats (via Pandoc)
Dendron	Y	Static site (Next.js)
Athens	N	--
Standard Notes	Y	Listed publishing platform
Org-roam	Y	HTML, PDF, LaTeX (Org export)
QOwnNotes	Y	PDF, HTML
zk	N	--
TidGi	Y	HTML, static site
Neuron	Y	Static site
Rocketnotes	N	--
Emanote	Y	Static site
Memo	N	--
Notabase	Y	Markdown
Zkn3	Y	HTML, PDF
iwe	N	--
vim-zettel	Y	HTML (via VimWiki)
Sublimeless_ZK	N	--

Feature Prevalence

How common each feature is across the 25 tools:

Feature	Count	Prevalence
Search	25/25	100%
Tags	24/25	96%
Offline support	23/25	92%
Markdown support	22/25	88%
Self-hosted	22/25	88%
Bi-directional linking	20/25	80%
Publishing/export	19/25	76%
Plugins/extensions	16/25	64%
File-based storage	16/25	64%

Feature	Count	Prevalence
Graph view	15/25	60%
Templates	14/25	56%
Version history	13/25	52%
WYSIWYG	11/25	44%
Embeds/transclusion	10/25	40%
API	10/25	40%
Encryption	8/25	32%
Daily notes	9/25	36%
Mobile support	8/25	32%
Web clipper	7/25	28%
CLI	8/25	32%
Block-level linking	6/25	24%
Collaboration	3/25	12%

Tool Categories

Full-featured PKM Platforms

Tools that aim to be comprehensive knowledge management systems:

- **SiYuan** - Block-level WYSIWYG, E2E encryption, self-hosted sync
- **Logseq** - Outliner-first, journal-centric, strong plugin ecosystem
- **TriliumNext** - Hierarchical notes, rich scripting, web clipper
- **Joplin** - Cross-platform, E2E encryption, extensive sync options

Editor-integrated (VS Code / Emacs / Vim)

Tools that extend existing editors:

- **Foam** - VS Code, Roam-inspired, Git-backed
- **Dendron** - VS Code, hierarchical schema system (unmaintained)
- **Memo** - VS Code, minimal bidirectional linking
- **Org-roam** - Emacs, Org-mode based, most mature in category
- **vim-zettel** - Vim, VimWiki-based
- **iwe** - Editor-agnostic via LSP (Neovim, Helix, VS Code, Zed)

CLI-first

Tools designed for terminal workflows:

- **nb** - Bash-based, bookmarking, encryption, Git versioning

- **zk** - Go, LSP server, plain text focused
- **Neuron** - Haskell, static site generation (superseded by Emanote)

Static Site Generators / Publishing

Tools focused on publishing Zettelkasten content:

- **Emanote** - Haskell, structured views of plain-text notes
- **Zettlr** - Academic focus, Pandoc integration

Desktop-native

Traditional desktop applications:

- **Zettlr** - Electron, academic writing focus
- **QOwnNotes** - Qt/C++, Nextcloud integration
- **Zkn3** - Java, faithful to Luhmann's original method
- **Standard Notes** - Zero-knowledge encryption focus
- **TiddlyWiki** - Single HTML file, highly extensible

Workspace / Notion alternatives

Broader workspace tools with some Zettelkasten features:

- **AppFlowy** - Flutter/Rust, AI-enhanced, real-time collaboration

AI-enhanced

Tools incorporating AI/LLM features:

- **Rocketnotes** - LLM integration for semantic search
- **SiYuan** - AI writing assistant features

Notable Proprietary Alternatives (not open source)

For reference, major closed-source tools in this space:

Tool	Notable For
Obsidian	Largest ecosystem, plugin marketplace, local-first
Roam Research	Pioneered bidirectional linking UX
The Archive	From zettelkasten.de, plain-text purist
Heptabase	Visual-first knowledge management
RemNote	Spaced repetition integration
DEVONthink	AI-powered document management (macOS)

Methodology

Data collected on 2026-02-23 using `ar-crawl` to crawl:

- GitHub repository pages for each tool
- GitHub Topics page for "zettelkasten"
- zettelkasten.de/tools
- Wikipedia Zettelkasten article
- Reddit [r/Zettelkasten](https://www.reddit.com/r/Zettelkasten) wiki

Star counts and activity status reflect data at time of crawl.